

LOCAL

Coralville advances license plate reader guidelines amid public privacy concerns

Ryan Hansen

Iowa City Press-Citizen

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Coralville passed guidelines intended to "prevent unauthorized access to data" and "abuse" of automated license plate reader technology by a thin margin as the council debated canceling the five-figure contract.

Much of the three-hour city council meeting on Tuesday, Sept. 23 revolved around council and public concern with the plate reader system and the possibility of canceling the contract between the Coralville Police Department and Flock Safety, rather than the proposed privacy policy.

The council's vote on the guidelines was 3-2, with Mike Knudson and Hai Huynh voting "no." Their votes reflected their concerns about the plate reader system, including that it might be misused in the "current political climate" by other governmental agencies to target individuals.

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Mayor Meghann Foster also expressed speculation about Flock as a company, but Coralville's mayor does not have a vote on the council's agenda items.

The contract between Flock Safety and the Coralville Police Department has already been signed. It runs for a period of two years, and the city budgeted about

\$36,000 for the contract in its fiscal 2026 budget. The two-year contract comes at a cost of \$18,000 annually for cameras, which have not yet been installed.

What are the regulations?

The council policy passed on Tuesday, Sept. 23, seeks to outline Coralville Police Department's use of the plate readers to "capture and store" license plate data "while recognizing the established privacy rights of the public."

The policy allows the use of license plate reader technology for "official law enforcement business," and it permits officers to use the plate reader technology once they have completed "department-approved training," though "reasonable suspicion or probable cause are not required" to consult the technology.

Each officer is identified by a unique user ID when they search the database. Coralville's policy requires officers who search the Flock database to provide a case number or call-for-service number and a "detailed reason" for the search.

The public search audit on Flock's transparency website for Coralville [shows 22 searches over the last month](#) from area databases for reasons including "arrest warrant," "hit and run," "assault" and "missing person."

The policy also makes clear that plate reader data cannot be used for any abusive purpose or "solely for immigration purposes." It outlines several protected characteristics that a search cannot be based on, including gender, sexual orientation, race, nationality or disability.

Councilors Huynh and Knudson signaled that they may want to amend this policy in the near future to create even stricter restrictions on law enforcement.

Coralville City Council finds narrow support for regulations

The Coralville City Council heard from numerous public commenters and asked questions to Flock's representative before engaging in a back-and-forth before their vote on the regulations.

Councilor Rich Vogelzang said he believed the cameras were part of the city's responsibility to provide for the "greater good" of the community and the Coralville Police Department.

"There are risks to everything," Vogelzang said, elaborating that he understood they would need to balance the risks and benefits.

He also called the cameras a "very, very important tool" for solving crimes, finding missing persons and more. He further cited concerns about whether both sides of the Flock camera debate, likely referencing supporters, had been heard. All public commenters were opposed to the cameras.

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Two councilors hinted that they would not be opposed to losing out on the \$36,000 investment by canceling the contract with Flock.

"For me, my concern is consent," Huynh said, citing her phone as an example. She knows and consents to having her phone with her, collecting data throughout the day. With Flock cameras, she said, "I have no control (over) whether I've given consent or not."

More: [It's a packed field for Coralville's mayoral, city council elections. Who's running?](#)

Councilor Royce Peterson was the swing vote on the regulations, as was the case at the council's previous meeting. He was initially "totally against" the cameras, but said he has seen their benefits in recent months and has even sat on a jury where automated license plate reader evidence was "beneficial."

"Everything inside me tells me that this is good for our constituents," Peterson said. "If we can save one child from getting kidnapped, if we can help somebody that their car has been stolen, if they help solve a murder, to me, that is very beneficial."

Flock representative met with questions from council, public

Flock representative Kam Simmons addressed concerns about the license plate reader technology during a lengthy question-and-answer session with Coralville's elected leaders and members of the public.

Simmons framed any council decision about how long to keep the data from Flock's automatic plate reader technology as a balance between "community input" regarding their privacy and "how much crime they want to solve."

All data is kept for 30 days before it is fully deleted from the Amazon Web Services-owned server where it is stored under the terms of the current contract, he said.

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The council expressed concerns about what the cameras capture, including bumper stickers and dents in the car. One public commenter worried about police being able to search for bumper stickers that champion Planned Parenthood or read "Make America Great Again."

Simmons said the cameras do catch that information, but Flock has fine-tuned its artificial intelligence to identify the "presence of a bumper sticker or roof rack" while not allowing specific sticker searches.

Simmons also said that Coralville could opt not to enter into a data "sharing" partnership with any area agencies and keep the Flock camera-generated license plate information to itself. The data would be owned by Coralville, he said, as is outlined by the contract.

It would not automatically be shared with the nationwide database unless desired by Coralville police, he said.

Residents plead with council over privacy, misuse

The public packed the council chambers on Tuesday to urge the five-member board to cancel its contract with Flock Safety over a myriad of privacy and data use concerns and a lack of trust in the company itself.

Aleksey Gurtovoy said he was "astonished" by the "level of gross incompetence" at all levels, from the city council, police chief, city administrator and city attorney in this process.

"We are not talking about trash removal," Gurtovoy said. "We are talking about mass surveillance."

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Katie Freeman, a candidate for the council, said an overwhelming majority of people they had talked to are concerned about Flock cameras, but felt like reaching out to the council was a futile pursuit.

"As elected officials, your position is given by the people to represent their wishes," Freeman said. "...It should be clear to you what the voice of the people are calling for. Please end this contract."

Ryan Hansen covers local government and crime for the Press-Citizen. He can be reached at trhansen@press-citizen.com or on X, formerly known as Twitter, [@ryanhansen01](https://twitter.com/ryanhansen01).

